

BIG 2

Also known as Deuces, Pusoy Dos, or Chinese Poker. A climbing card game for exactly four players. Each player receives 13 cards and tries to be the first to empty their hand by playing progressively higher combinations.

SETUP

- ♦ 4 players. Deal all 52 cards evenly (13 each).
- ♦ Player with the 3 of Diamonds leads the first round.
- ♦ Subsequent rounds: loser of previous round leads.

CARD RANKING

Rank (low to high): 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, J, Q, K, A, 2

Suit (low to high): Diamonds, Clubs, Hearts, Spades

The 2 of Spades is the highest card in the game.

COMBINATION TYPES

TYPE	CARDS	RANKING
Single	1 card	By rank, then suit
Pair	2 same rank	By rank of pair, then highest suit
Triple	3 same rank	By rank
Five-card hand	5 cards	By poker hand type, then by highest card

Five-card hand ranking (low to high): Straight, Flush, Full House, Four of a Kind, Straight Flush, Royal Flush.

RULES

- 1 Lead player plays any valid combination.
- 2 Each subsequent player must play the same combination type at a higher value, or pass.
- 3 When all other players pass, the last player who played leads the next trick.
- 4 The first player to empty their hand wins.
- 5 Remaining players are ranked by finishing order.

PASSING

A player who passes may play again when the turn comes back around (unless the trick is already won). Passing is strategic, not permanent.

ATTRIBUTION

Big 2. Traditional Chinese climbing card game, widespread across East and Southeast Asia. Public domain. Rules confirmed from Pagat.com and Wikipedia.

BLACKJACK (TWENTY-ONE)

Blackjack is a casino card game in which each player competes independently against the dealer. The goal is to hold a hand with a total closer to 21 than the dealer's without exceeding 21 (busting). Blackjack (an Ace + a 10-value card) beats a regular 21 and pays 3:2. The standard casino game uses 6–8 decks shuffled together.

CARD VALUES

CARD	VALUE
2–10	Face value
J, Q, K	10
Ace	1 or 11 (player chooses; always the value that benefits the hand without busting)

A **soft** hand contains an Ace counted as 11. A **hard** hand has no Ace, or an Ace counted as 1.

SETUP AND BETTING

- ♦ 1–6 players plus a dealer.
- ♦ Casino: 6 or 8 standard decks in a shoe. Home game: 1–2 decks.
- ♦ Each player places a bet before cards are dealt.

DEAL

Dealer deals two cards to each player face-up, then deals themselves two cards: one face-up (upcard) and one face-down (hole card).

BLACKJACK (NATURAL)

If a player's first two cards are an Ace and a 10-value card, they have **Blackjack**. The player wins immediately and is paid 3:2 on their bet, unless the dealer also has Blackjack (in which case it is a push — bet returned, no win or loss).

Insurance: If the dealer's upcard is an Ace, players may place an insurance bet (up to half the original bet) that the dealer has Blackjack. If the dealer has Blackjack, insurance pays 2:1. If not, the insurance bet is lost and play continues.

PLAYER ACTIONS

Each player acts on their hand before the dealer plays. Options:

ACTION	DESCRIPTION
Hit	Take one additional card. May hit again as many times as desired (until standing or busting).
Stand	Take no more cards; end the turn.
Double Down	Double the bet and take exactly one more card. Only allowed on the initial two-card hand (some rules restrict to totals of 9, 10, or 11 only).
Split	If the first two cards are of equal value, split them into two separate hands, each with its own bet equal to the original. Each hand is then played independently. Aces may only be split once and receive one card each; no further actions allowed after splitting Aces in most casinos.
Surrender	Forfeit the hand and recover half the bet. Only on the initial two cards, before any other action. Not available at all tables.

Bust: If a hand total exceeds 21, the player busts and loses the bet immediately. The dealer does not need to play.

DEALER PLAY

After all players have acted, the dealer reveals the hole card.

- Dealer must **hit** on any total of 16 or less.
- Dealer must **stand** on any total of 17 or more.
- **Soft 17:** Some rules require the dealer to hit on soft 17 (Ace + 6 = 17 with the Ace as 11). Others require a stand. The rule in use should be stated.

The dealer has no choices — their play is entirely rule-determined.

SETTLEMENT

After the dealer completes their hand:

RESULT	PAYOUT
Player total > dealer total (no bust)	Player wins 1:1 (even money)
Player Blackjack (natural 21)	Player wins 3:2
Player total = dealer total	Push (bet returned)
Player busts (exceeded 21)	Player loses bet
Dealer busts	All remaining players win 1:1
Dealer total > player total	Player loses bet

BASIC STRATEGY SUMMARY

Basic strategy is the set of statistically optimal player decisions for every hand combination given the dealer upcard.

Key principles:

- ♦ Always split Aces and 8s.
- ♦ Never split 10-value cards or 5s.
- ♦ Double down on 11 against dealer's 2–10; on 10 against dealer's 2–9.
- ♦ Stand on hard 17+; hit on hard 8 or less.
- ♦ Stand on soft 19+; always hit soft 17 or less.

CARD COUNTING (INFORMATIONAL)

Card counting is a legal advantage technique where players track the ratio of high to low cards remaining in the shoe. A high count (more 10s and Aces remaining) favors the player; a low count favors the dealer. Casinos may bar known card counters from play but it is not illegal.

ATTRIBUTION

Blackjack (Twenty-One). Origins in 17th century France (Vingt-et-Un). Modern casino rules standardized during the 20th century. Public domain rule set. Casino rules vary by establishment; house rules should be confirmed before play.

RUBBER BRIDGE

Rubber Bridge is the classic home and club form of Contract Bridge, played by four players in two partnerships (North–South vs. East–West). Bridge combines a bidding phase — an auction to determine the contract — with a trick-taking phase where the declaring partnership attempts to fulfil the contract. A rubber is the best of three games.

SETUP

- ♦ 4 players in fixed partnerships: North–South and East–West.
- ♦ Two standard 52-card decks (alternated between deals).
- ♦ Determine the first dealer by drawing a card; high card deals. The deal rotates clockwise.

DEAL

Dealer distributes all 52 cards clockwise, one at a time, face down. Each player receives 13 cards.

CARD RANKINGS

Within each suit (high to low): A, K, Q, J, 10, 9, 8, 7, 6, 5, 4, 3, 2.

Suit ranking (for notrump and slam purposes): Spades > Hearts > Diamonds > Clubs.

High Card Points (HCP): Ace = 4, King = 3, Queen = 2, Jack = 1. A standard 52-card deck contains 40 HCP. An opening hand typically requires 12–13+ HCP.

THE AUCTION (BIDDING)

Starting with the dealer, players bid in clockwise order. A bid names a number (1–7) and a strain (Clubs, Diamonds, Hearts, Spades, or Notrump). The number represents how many tricks above 6 the partnership contracts to take (e.g., a bid of 3 Hearts contracts for 9 tricks with Hearts as trump).

Calls: Players may bid (any legal bid higher than the previous), pass, double (if the previous call was a bid by an opponent), or redouble (if the previous call was a double by an opponent).

Auction ends: Three consecutive passes end the auction. The final bid becomes the contract. If all four players pass immediately (a passed-out hand), the hand is redealt with no score.

The declarer: The first player on the contracting partnership who named the strain of the final contract becomes the declarer. The declarer's left-hand opponent leads the first trick.

THE PLAY

Dummy: After the opening lead, the declarer's partner (dummy) lays all cards face-up on the table, arranged by suit. The dummy plays no active role; the declarer calls plays from dummy's hand.

Tricks: Each trick consists of four cards, one per player, played clockwise. A player must follow suit if able; if unable, may play any card. The highest card of the led suit wins the trick unless a trump card has been played, in which case the highest trump wins. Winner of each trick leads the next.

Trump: The trump suit (if any) is named by the contract. In Notrump, there is no trump suit.

SCORING

Scoring is cumulative on a scorecard divided into "below the line" (trick points) and "above the line" (bonuses and penalties).

Trick points (below the line):

STRAIN	PER OVERTRICK (VALUE)	PER TRICK CONTRACTED
Clubs or Diamonds (minor suits)	20 per trick	20 per trick
Hearts or Spades (major suits)	30 per trick	30 per trick
Notrump	40 for first trick, 30 per subsequent	Same

Game: A partnership reaches game when their trick points below the line total 100 or more in a single game. The contract must be fulfilled to score below the line (undertricks score only penalties above the line).

Vulnerable: A partnership that has won one game in the current rubber is "vulnerable." Bonuses and penalties are higher when vulnerable.

Doubled and redoubled contracts: A doubled contract that is made scores trick points $\times 2$ (below the line). Redoubled: $\times 4$. A "Insult bonus" of 50 above the line also applies for making a doubled or redoubled contract.

Bonuses (above the line):

BONUS	AMOUNT
Small Slam (12 tricks) — not vulnerable	500
Small Slam — vulnerable	750
Grand Slam (13 tricks) — not vulnerable	1000
Grand Slam — vulnerable	1500
Rubber bonus (won 2–0)	700
Rubber bonus (won 2–1)	500
Part-score if rubber unfinished	50

Overtricks (above the line):

CONDITION	PER OVERTICK
Undoubled	Trick value (20 or 30)
Doubled, not vulnerable	100
Doubled, vulnerable	200
Redoubled, not vulnerable	200
Redoubled, vulnerable	400

Undertricks (penalties, above the line against the declaring partnership):

TRICKS SHORT	UNDOUBLED	DOUBLED NV	DOUBLED V	REDOUBLED NV	REDOUBLED V
1	50	100	200	200	400
2	100	300	500	600	1000
3	150	500	800	1000	1600
Each additional	+50	+300 NV / +300 V	same	+600	+600

RUBBER

A rubber consists of up to three games. The first partnership to win two games wins the rubber. Game points are totalled; the partnership with the higher total wins.

HONOURS (OPTIONAL)

If one player holds 4 of the 5 top honours (A, K, Q, J, 10) in the trump suit, that player's partnership scores 100 above the line. All 5 top honours in one hand: 150 above the line. In Notrump, 4 Aces in one hand: 150. Honours are scored regardless of which side wins the contract.

ATTRIBUTION

Contract Bridge. Formalized by Harold Vanderbilt, 1925–1926. Rubber Bridge scoring codified by the World Bridge Federation. Public domain rule set.

CANASTA (CLASSIC)

Canasta is a partnership rummy-style game for four players (two teams of two). The game uses two standard 52-card decks plus 4 Jokers (108 cards total). Players build melds — groups of three or more cards of the same rank — aiming to form Canastas (melds of 7 or more cards). The first partnership to reach 5000 points wins.

Canasta originated in Uruguay in the 1940s and became internationally popular in the 1950s.

CARD VALUES

CARD	POINT VALUE
Joker	50
Ace or 2	20
K, Q, J, 10, 9, 8	10
7, 6, 5, 4	5
Black 3 (bonus/block card)	5
Red 3 (bonus card)	100 (or 200 if all four are held)

WILD CARDS

Wild cards: All four Jokers and all eight 2s (Deuces) are wild. Wild cards may substitute for any natural card in a meld.

Rules for wild cards in melds:

- ♦ A meld may contain at most 3 wild cards.
- ♦ A meld must always contain more natural cards than wild cards (e.g., 2 natural + 1 wild is fine; 2 natural + 2 wild is the maximum and only legal if there are 3 natural cards total).

SPECIAL CARDS

Red 3s: When drawn or dealt, a Red 3 must be placed face-up on the table immediately and replaced by drawing from the stock. Red 3s score a bonus at the end of the game (100 each; 800 for all four held by one partnership). Red 3s count for the partnership only if they have at least one canasta; otherwise they count against.

Black 3s: May not be melded during play (except as the final card in a hand, see Going Out). Black 3s may be discarded to freeze the pile for one turn against the next player (a one-turn block). Cannot be used as wild cards.

SETUP

- ♦ 4 players in fixed partnerships. Partners sit opposite.
- ♦ Shuffle both decks together with all 4 Jokers for a 108-card deck.
- ♦ Deal 11 cards each (44 total). Place the remaining cards as the stock.
- ♦ Turn over the top card to begin the discard pile (the pack).
- ♦ If the initial upcard is a Joker, 2, or Red 3: bury it in the stock and turn another.
- ♦ If the initial upcard is a Black 3: the first player may not pick up the pack on their first turn; the Black 3 remains.

TAKING A TURN

Each turn consists of:

- 1 **Draw:** Take the top card from the stock OR take the entire discard pile (the pack) — subject to restrictions below.
- 2 **Meld:** Optionally create or extend melds on the table. Red 3s must be immediately placed.
- 3 **Discard:** Place one card face-up onto the discard pile. (Exception: do not discard when going out by melding all cards.)

TAKING THE PACK (DISCARD PILE)

A player may take the entire discard pile if:

- ♦ The top card of the pile is a natural card (not wild, not Black 3).
- ♦ The player holds at least two natural cards of the same rank as the top card and can immediately use them to meld with the top card.
- ♦ The partnership has already made its initial meld (see Initial Meld Requirement).

Frozen Pack: The discard pile is frozen when a wild card or Red 3 has been placed on it. To take a frozen pack, the player must hold two natural cards matching the top card (not just one plus a wild) and the rules above still apply. The pile unfreezes when picked up.

INITIAL MELD REQUIREMENT

A partnership's first meld(s) of the game must meet a minimum point value based on their current score:

PARTNERSHIP'S CURRENT SCORE	MINIMUM INITIAL MELD VALUE
Negative	15
0–1499	50
1500–2999	90
3000+	120

Once the initial meld is made, subsequent melds have no minimum.

MELDS

A meld is three or more cards of the same rank, placed face-up in front of the partnership. Valid ranks: 4 through Ace (2s and Jokers are wild; 3s are special). Natural melds contain no wild cards. Mixed melds contain 1–3 wild cards.

Partners share their melds: either partner may extend any of their partnership's melds on their turn.

CANASTAS

A **Canasta** is a complete meld of 7 or more cards. It is squared into a pile:

- ♦ **Natural Canasta (Clean):** 7 or more natural cards (no wild cards). Marked with a red card on top. Bonus: **500 points**.
- ♦ **Mixed Canasta (Dirty):** 7 or more cards including at least one wild card. Marked with a black card on top. Bonus: **300 points**.

A partnership must have at least one complete Canasta to go out.

GOING OUT

A player goes out by melding all remaining cards from their hand (including the final discard, or by melding all without discarding). The partnership must have at least one Canasta.

Asking permission: A player may ask their partner “Can I go out?” before going out; the partner must answer yes or no, and the decision is binding. This optional courtesy prevents surprise endings.

Going out concealed: If a player melds their entire hand in one turn without having previously melded any cards, they have gone out concealed. Bonus: **100 extra points** (in addition to the standard 100 go-out bonus).

SCORING (END OF HAND)

Going-out bonus: 100 points.

Each partnership scores:

- ♦ Value of all cards in completed melds and canastas

- ♦ Canasta bonuses (500 per natural, 300 per mixed)

- ♦ Red 3 bonuses (if at least one canasta held)

- ♦ Going-out bonus (if applicable)

Minus:

- ♦ Value of cards remaining in hand (cards not melded)

- ♦ Red 3 penalties (if no canasta held, Red 3s count against)

END OF GAME

The first partnership to accumulate 5000 or more points at the end of a hand wins.

ATTRIBUTION

Canasta. Originated in Montevideo, Uruguay, approximately 1939. Popularized internationally in the 1950s. Standard North American rules confirmed from Pagat.com and Hoyle's Rules of Games. Public domain rule set.

CRIBBAGE

Cribbage is a two-player card game in which the primary goal is to be the first to peg 121 points on a cribbage board. Points are scored in three phases: the deal (crib), the pegging phase (playing out cards alternately), and the show (hand counting after play). Attributed to the poet Sir John Suckling (England, early 17th century).

THE CRIBBAGE BOARD

Each player has a track of 120 holes (pegging twice around a 60-hole board) plus a game hole at 121. Two pegs per player allow tracking from 0 to 121. The game ends immediately when any player's front peg reaches or passes hole 121.

CARD VALUES

- ♦ **Number cards (A–10):** Face value (Ace = 1).
- ♦ **Face cards (J, Q, K):** All worth 10.
- ♦ **Ranking** (for sequences and cutting): A, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, J, Q, K (Ace is always low).

DEAL

Deal 6 cards each. Each player discards 2 cards face-down to the crib — a second hand owned by the dealer. The crib is scored by the dealer at the end of the round.

Strategy note: The non-dealer (pone) generally avoids giving good cards to the crib; the dealer welcomes strong crib contributions.

THE CUT (STARTER CARD)

After discarding, the non-dealer cuts the remaining deck. The dealer reveals the top card of the lower half — this is the **starter card** (also called the turn-up). It is used in scoring all hands during the show.

Nibs (Heels): If the starter card is a Jack, the dealer immediately pegs 2 points (“Two for his heels”).

PEGGING PHASE

Alternating starting with the non-dealer, players lay cards one at a time face-up, calling out the cumulative running total (never exceeding 31).

Pegging scores during play:

EVENT	POINTS
Reaching exactly 15 (cumulative total)	2
Reaching exactly 31	2
“Go” (opponent cannot play without exceeding 31)	1
Last card played (if total is not 31)	1
Pair (consecutive same-rank card)	2
Three of a kind (three consecutive same rank)	6
Four of a kind (four consecutive same rank)	12
Run of 3 (consecutive ranks in last 3+ cards played)	3
Run of 4	4
Run of 5	5

Go rule: When a player cannot play without exceeding 31, they say “Go.” The opponent continues playing cards if they can. After a Go (or when 31 is reached), the running total resets to 0 and the player who did not last play begins a new sequence.

THE SHOW (HAND SCORING)

After pegging, players score their hands using the starter card as a fifth card. The pone (non-dealer) scores first, then the dealer, then the dealer scores the crib.

Scoring combinations (each combination scores separately):

COMBINATION	POINTS	NOTES
Fifteen: Any combination of cards summing to 15	2 per fifteen	Ace=1, J/Q/K=10
Pair: Two cards of the same rank	2 per pair	
Pair Royal (Three of a kind):	6 (three pairs)	
Double Pair Royal (Four of a kind):	12 (six pairs)	
Run of 3: Three cards in sequence	3	
Run of 4: Four cards in sequence	4	
Run of 5: Five cards in sequence	5	
Flush (4 cards same suit in hand):	4	Starter card not required. Not counted in crib unless all 5 cards match.
Flush (5 cards same suit, including starter):	5	
Nobs: Jack of same suit as starter card	1	One Jack in hand matching starter suit.

Maximum hand: 29 points (three 5s and a Jack in hand, starter is the 5 of the same suit as the Jack — allowing 8 fifteens, 6 pairs, one nobs).

MUGGINS (OPTIONAL)

If a player fails to peg points they earned, the opponent may call “Muggins” and claim those points. Commonly used in competitive play; optional in casual games.

GAME VARIANTS

Three-player Cribbage: 5 cards dealt each, 1 discarded to crib; extra card dealt directly to crib. Play proceeds clockwise. First to 121 wins.

Four-player Cribbage: Teams of two (partners sitting opposite). 5 cards each, 1 discarded to crib. Partners’ scores are combined. First team to 121 wins.

Six-card Cribbage: Standard two-player game where 6 cards are dealt and 2 are discarded to the crib (same as standard rules above).

ATTRIBUTION

Cribbage. Attributed to Sir John Suckling, England, early 17th century. Public domain. Standard rules confirmed from Pagat.com and the American Cribbage Congress.

EUCHRE

Euchre is a partnership trick-taking game for four players using only the 24 highest-ranked cards from a standard deck (remove all 2s through 8s). It is especially popular in the American Midwest and Ontario, Canada. The critical Euchre rule is the **Bower system**: the two Jacks of the trump suit (and its same-color counterpart suit) are the two most powerful cards in the game.

DECK

Remove all 2s, 3s, 4s, 5s, 6s, 7s, and 8s. Play with the remaining 24 cards:

SUIT	CARDS
Each of 4 suits	9, 10, J, Q, K, A

PARTNERSHIPS AND SEATING

- ♦ 4 players in fixed partnerships: Player 1 & Player 3 vs. Player 2 & Player 4.
- ♦ Partners sit opposite each other.
- ♦ Dealer rotates clockwise each hand.

DEAL

Deal 5 cards to each player (20 total) in two rounds of dealing — typically 2–3 or 3–2 cards per player per round (exact dealing pattern is regional but the result is always 5 cards each).

Turn the 21st card face-up on the table to propose trump. The remaining 3 cards are set aside (the kitty or blind) and are not used.

SELECTING TRUMP

Round 1: Starting with the player left of the dealer, each player may **order up** (tell the dealer to take the upcard, making its suit trump) or **pass**. If a player orders up:

- ♦ The dealer takes the upcard into hand and discards one card face-down (the kitty).
- ♦ The suit of the upcard becomes trump for this hand.
- ♦ The player who ordered up (or their partner) becomes the **maker**.

Round 2 (if all pass in Round 1): The upcard is turned face-down and play proceeds to Round 2. Starting with the player left of the dealer, each player may name any suit (except the suit of the turned-down upcard) as trump or pass. The dealer must name trump if all others pass (**stuck the dealer**). The player who names trump becomes the maker.

TRUMP AND THE BOWER SYSTEM

Once trump is set, the trump suit card rankings change:

CARD	RANK (IN TRUMP SUIT)
Right Bower — Jack of trump suit	Highest trump card
Left Bower — Jack of the same-color suit (e.g., if trump is Hearts, the Jack of Diamonds is Left Bower)	Second-highest trump card; treated as trump (not as its original suit)
Ace of trump	Third-highest trump card
K, Q, 10, 9 of trump	In descending order

The Left Bower belongs to the trump suit for all purposes — it is played as trump, not as its original suit. Its original suit effectively loses its Jack for that hand.

Non-trump suit rankings (high to low): A, K, Q, J (if not Left Bower), 10, 9.

PLAYING TRICKS

The player to the left of the dealer leads the first trick. Players must follow suit if able. If unable, they may play any card including trump. The highest card of the led suit wins the trick, unless trump has been played, in which case the highest trump wins.

The winner of each trick leads the next.

GOING ALONE

When a player orders up or names trump, they may declare “Going Alone” before the first lead. Their partner sits out the hand (discards hand face-down). The lone player competes against both opponents.

If a lone player wins all 5 tricks, they score 4 points. Winning 3–4 tricks: 1 point. Losing: opponents score 2 points.

SCORING

RESULT	POINTS
Makers win 3 or 4 tricks	1 point
Makers win all 5 tricks (March)	2 points
Makers go alone and win 3–4 tricks	1 point
Makers go alone and win all 5 tricks	4 points
Makers win fewer than 3 tricks (Euchre)	Opponents score 2 points

FIRST TO 10 POINTS

The first partnership to reach 10 points wins the game. Scoring is tracked with cards (5 of a suit covering a 6, or a 3 and 4 held together) or any scoring method agreed upon.

VARIANTS

Bid Euchre (Pepper): Players bid the exact number of tricks they expect to take; no upcard / Round 2 selection. Wider bidding options.

Stick the Dealer: A mandatory rule in some regions — if all three players pass in Round 2, the dealer is forced to name trump (cannot pass). This prevents passed-out hands and is common in North American play.

No-trump declaration: In some variants, players may call “No Trump” in Round 2, in which case there is no trump suit for the hand.

ATTRIBUTION

Euchre. Traditional card game, likely descended from the Alsatian game Juckerspiel. Widely played in North America since the 19th century. Public domain rule set confirmed from [Pagat.com](https://www.pagat.com/euchre/).

GIN RUMMY

Gin Rummy is a two-player draw-and-discard card game. Players draw and discard to build melds (sets and runs) in their hand, aiming to reduce unmatched card value (deadwood) to zero or low enough to knock. The game was created by Elwood T. Baker and his son C. Graham Baker in 1909.

DEAL

Deal 10 cards to each player. Place the remaining cards face-down as the stock. Turn the top card face-up to start the discard pile.

CARD VALUES (FOR DEADWOOD)

- ♦ **Ace:** 1 point
- ♦ **Number cards (2–10):** Face value
- ♦ **Face cards (J, Q, K):** 10 points

MELDS

A meld is a matched set of cards that score no deadwood:

- ♦ **Set:** Three or four cards of the same rank (e.g., 7♥ 7♦ 7♣).
- ♦ **Run (Sequence):** Three or more cards of the same suit in consecutive rank order (e.g., 4♥ 5♥ 6♥). Ace is always low (A–2–3 is valid; Q–K–A is not).

A card may belong to only one meld. Unmelded cards are **deadwood**.

TAKING A TURN

On each turn, a player must:

- 1 **Draw:** Take the top card from either the stock or the discard pile.
- 2 **Discard:** Place one card face-up on top of the discard pile (may be the card just drawn from stock, but not the card drawn from the discard pile on the same turn).

First turn exception: The non-dealer may take the face-up card or pass. If they pass, the dealer may take it or pass. If both pass, the non-dealer draws from stock and the game begins normally.

KNOCKING

After drawing (but before discarding), a player may **knock** if their deadwood totals 10 points or less. They discard one card face-down (the knock card) and lay all their melds face-up.

The opponent then lays off any cards from their hand onto the knocker's melds (to reduce their own deadwood), then reveals their remaining deadwood.

Scoring the knock:

- ♦ If the knocker's deadwood < opponent's deadwood after layoffs: Knocker scores the difference.
- ♦ If the knocker's deadwood ≥ opponent's deadwood after layoffs: **Undercut**. Opponent scores the difference plus a 25-point undercut bonus.

GOING GIN

If a player knocks with zero deadwood (all 10 cards in melds), they have **gone Gin**. The opponent may not lay off cards. The Gin player scores the opponent's full deadwood plus a 25-point Gin bonus.

BIG GIN

If a player can meld all 11 cards in hand (after drawing, before discarding) — i.e., all 11 form valid melds — they may declare **Big Gin** without discarding. Score: opponent's deadwood + 31 points.

END OF STOCK

If the stock reaches 2 cards and neither player has knocked, the hand ends in a draw with no points scored. The same dealer deals the next hand.

GAME SCORING

Play continues hand by hand until one player reaches 100 or more points.

End-of-game bonuses:

BONUS	POINTS
Game bonus (winner)	100
Box bonus (per hand won)	25 per hand
Shutout bonus (opponent scored 0)	Additional 100 (total game bonus becomes 200)

Final score = game points + box bonuses + shutout bonus (if applicable). The player with more total points wins.

ATtribution

Gin Rummy. Created by Elwood T. Baker and C. Graham Baker, 1909. Public domain. Standard rules confirmed from [Pagat.com](https://www.pagat.com/gin/ginrummy/).

HEARTS

Hearts is a trick-avoidance game for four players. The goal is to end the game with the lowest score. Hearts cards and the Queen of Spades carry penalty points — players want to avoid winning tricks containing these cards. However, a player who collects every penalty card in a single hand “Shoots the Moon” and scores zero while opponents each receive 26 points.

SETUP

- ♦ 4 players. Standard 52-card deck, no jokers.
- ♦ Shuffle and deal all 52 cards (13 per player).

PASSING

Before play begins, each player selects 3 cards from their hand and passes them to another player. The passing direction rotates each hand:

- ♦ Hand 1: Pass to the left
- ♦ Hand 2: Pass to the right
- ♦ Hand 3: Pass across (opposite player)
- ♦ Hand 4: No passing (hold all cards)
- ♦ Repeat cycle.

Players receive cards from the appropriate direction before looking at what they were passed.

LEAD

The player holding the 2 of Clubs leads it to begin the first trick. In subsequent tricks, the winner of the previous trick leads.

FOLLOWING SUIT AND BREAKING HEARTS

- ♦ **Must follow suit** if able. If unable to follow suit, any card may be played.
- ♦ **Hearts may not be led** until Hearts has been “broken” — that is, until a Heart has been discarded (played off-suit) on a previous trick. Exception: if a player has only Hearts remaining, they may lead a Heart regardless.
- ♦ **First trick restriction:** No penalty cards (Hearts or Queen of Spades) may be played on the first trick, unless the player has no Clubs.

TRICK WINNING

Highest card of the led suit wins the trick. There is no trump suit. The winner of each trick collects the cards and leads the next trick.

CARD RANKINGS

Within each suit (high to low): A, K, Q, J, 10, 9, 8, 7, 6, 5, 4, 3, 2.

PENALTY CARDS

CARD	PENALTY POINTS
Each Heart	1 point
Queen of Spades	13 points
Total per hand	26 points

The Jack of Diamonds (“Parker” or “Black Maria” variant) sometimes awards –10 points to whoever wins it — this is optional and not part of the standard rules.

SHOOTING THE MOON

If one player collects ALL 13 Hearts AND the Queen of Spades in a single hand, that player “Shoots the Moon.” Rather than scoring 26 points, the shooter may choose:

- ♦ Add 26 points to each opponent’s score (shooter scores 0), OR
- ♦ Subtract 26 points from their own score.

The shooter selects which option is more advantageous. If the shooter’s score would go below zero with the subtraction option, it becomes 0.

Shooting the Sun (optional): If the same player also wins all 13 tricks (not just the penalty cards), they score 0 and all others receive 52 points (double the moon). This is an optional rule.

END OF HAND

After all 13 tricks are played, each player scores penalty points for the penalty cards in their won tricks. Scores are cumulative across hands.

END OF GAME

The game ends after the hand in which any player reaches 100 points or more. The player with the lowest score at that point wins. If two or more players tie for lowest, play continues until the tie is broken.

VARIATIONS

Omnibus Hearts: Adds the Jack of Diamonds as a bonus card (player who wins it subtracts 10 from their score). Makes Shooting the Moon include winning the Jack of Diamonds too for the full bonus.

3-Player Hearts: Remove the 2 of Clubs from the deck (deal 17 cards each). The player with the 2 of Diamonds leads.

5-Player Hearts: Remove the 2 of Clubs and 2 of Diamonds (deal 10 cards each).

ATTRIBUTION

Hearts. Traditional American card game, widely popular from the 19th century onward. Public domain. Standard rules confirmed from Pagat.com.

KLONDIKE SOLITAIRE

Klondike is the most widely played solitaire (patience) game in the world and the game most people mean when they say “Solitaire.” The goal is to move all 52 cards to four foundation piles, one per suit, built from Ace to King.

SETUP

Foundations (4 piles, top right): Start empty. Each foundation is built up in suit from Ace (↓) to King (↑). Completed foundation: A, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, J, Q, K.

Tableau (7 columns):

- ♦ Column 1: 1 card (face-up)
- ♦ Column 2: 2 cards (1 face-down, 1 face-up)
- ♦ Column 3: 3 cards (2 face-down, 1 face-up)
- ♦ Column 4: 4 cards (3 face-down, 1 face-up)
- ♦ Column 5: 5 cards (4 face-down, 1 face-up)
- ♦ Column 6: 6 cards (5 face-down, 1 face-up)
- ♦ Column 7: 7 cards (6 face-down, 1 face-up)

Total dealt: 28 cards. The remaining 24 cards form the **stock**.

BUILDING THE TABLEAU

Face-up cards in the tableau may be moved according to these rules:

- ♦ Cards are stacked in **descending rank** (King = high, Ace = low).
- ♦ Colors must **alternate**: a red card on a black card, or a black card on a red card.
- ♦ A face-up card (or sequence of face-up cards) may be moved onto any tableau card that is one rank higher and of the opposite color.
- ♦ An empty tableau column may only receive a **King** (or a sequence headed by a King).
- ♦ When a face-down card is exposed (all face-up cards above it have been moved), it is turned face-up.

Example: A red 7 may be placed on a black 8. A black 6 may then be placed on that red 7, and so on.

THE STOCK AND WASTE PILE

When no more moves are available in the tableau, the player draws from the stock.

Draw 1: Flip one card at a time from the stock to the waste pile. The top card of the waste pile is always available to play.

Draw 3: Flip three cards at a time from the stock to the waste pile. Only the top card of the waste pile is available. This is the traditional rule and makes the game significantly harder.

Recycling the stock: When the stock is exhausted, flip the waste pile over (without shuffling) to form a new stock and continue drawing. In classic Klondike, the stock may be recycled an unlimited number of times (infinite pass) — though many competitive versions limit redeals to 3 passes (Draw 3) or 1 pass (Draw 1) for scoring purposes.

MOVING TO FOUNDATIONS

Any available Ace may be moved to an empty foundation at any time. Subsequent cards move to a foundation only when they are one rank higher than the top card of that foundation and of the same suit.

Cards may be moved from foundations back to the tableau if needed, though this is rarely advantageous.

WINNING

The game is won when all 52 cards are on the four foundations (each foundation completed from A to K).

SCORING (MICROSOFT / CLASSIC)

Many digital implementations use a point system:

ACTION	POINTS
Moving a card from stock to tableau	5
Moving a card to a foundation	10
Flipping a face-down tableau card	5
Moving a card from waste to tableau	5
Moving a card back from foundation to tableau	−5
Each 10 seconds elapsed	−2 (timed scoring)

Untimed scoring: Bonus = 700 − (total time in seconds), multiplied by some factor in some implementations.

VARIANTS

Vegas Scoring: Players “buy” a deck for \$52 and earn \$5 per card moved to the foundations (maximum \$260). Recycling the stock costs \$0 (Draw 1) or is not permitted (Draw 3). Net profit/loss is tracked.

Thoughtful Klondike: All face-down cards are revealed at the start. Useful for analysis; reduces luck significantly.

Double Klondike: Two decks, 9 or 10 tableau columns, 8 foundations. Harder; longer game.

ATTRIBUTION

Klondike. Name associated with the Klondike Gold Rush (1896–1899); exact origin unclear. Popularized globally through Microsoft Solitaire (Windows 3.0, 1990). Public domain rule set.

TEXAS HOLD'EM POKER

Texas Hold'em is the most widely played poker variant in the world and the standard format for professional tournaments. Players combine two private hole cards with five shared community cards to make the best possible five-card poker hand.

SETUP

- ♦ 2–10 players.
- ♦ One standard 52-card deck, no jokers.
- ♦ Designate a dealer button (rotates clockwise each hand).
- ♦ **Blinds:** The player immediately left of the dealer posts the small blind; the next player posts the big blind (typically double the small blind). Blinds create forced starting action.

DEAL

Each player is dealt 2 private cards face down (hole cards). Dealing begins with the player to the left of the dealer.

BETTING ROUNDS

There are four betting rounds. In each round, players may fold, check (if no bet yet made), call (match the current bet), raise (increase the bet), or re-raise.

- 1 Preflop:** After hole cards are dealt. The player left of the big blind acts first. The big blind acts last and may raise even if no one else has.
- 2 Flop:** Three community cards are dealt face-up to the center. Betting begins with the first active player left of the dealer button.
- 3 Turn:** A fourth community card is dealt face-up. Betting proceeds.
- 4 River:** A fifth and final community card is dealt face-up. Final betting round.

SHOWDOWN

If two or more players remain after the final betting round, all remaining players reveal their hole cards. The player with the best five-card hand wins the pot.

Players may use any combination of their two hole cards and the five community cards to form the best five-card hand (both hole cards, one hole card, or no hole cards — “playing the board”).

HAND RANKINGS (HIGH TO LOW)

HAND	DESCRIPTION	EXAMPLE
Royal Flush	A, K, Q, J, 10 of one suit	A♥ K♥ Q♥ J♥ 10♥
Straight Flush	Five consecutive cards, same suit	7♠ 8♠ 9♠ 10♠ J♠
Four of a Kind	Four cards of the same rank	K K K K 7
Full House	Three of a kind + a pair	Q Q Q 4 4
Flush	Five cards of the same suit	A 9 7 4 2 (all hearts)
Straight	Five consecutive ranks, any suits	5 6 7 8 9
Three of a Kind	Three cards of the same rank	J J J 9 3
Two Pair	Two separate pairs	K K 7 7 A
Pair	One pair	10 10 A K 3
High Card	No combination	A J 8 5 2

Ties are broken by the highest card in the hand. If still tied, the pot is split.

BETTING FORMATS

- ♦ **No-Limit:** Players may bet any amount up to all their chips at any time. Standard for tournaments.
- ♦ **Pot-Limit:** Maximum bet equals the current pot size.
- ♦ **Fixed-Limit:** Bets and raises are fixed at a set amount per street (smaller bet preflop/flop, larger on turn/river).

ALL-IN

A player who cannot match a bet may go all-in, wagering all remaining chips. Side pots are created for any additional bets among players who still have chips.

TOURNAMENT VS. CASH GAME

- ♦ **Cash game (ring game):** Players buy in for real money or chips with cash value. Blinds are fixed. Players may leave or rebuy freely.
- ♦ **Tournament:** Players start with equal chip stacks. Blinds increase on a schedule. Last player with chips wins.

ATTRIBUTION

Texas Hold'em. Origin attributed to Texas (early 20th century), popularized in Las Vegas from the 1960s onward. Public domain rules. World Series of Poker standard ruleset.

PRESIDENT

Also known as Scum, Asshole, or Capitalism. A multi-round climbing card game where finishing position in each round determines your role (and advantages) in the next.

SETUP

- ♦ 4 to 8 players
- ♦ Standard 52-card deck (no jokers), dealt evenly (discard remainders or give to President)
- ♦ First round: player with 3 of clubs leads. Subsequent rounds: Scum leads

ROLES (FROM PREVIOUS ROUND)

POSITION	ROLE	ADVANTAGE
1st out	President	Receives 2 best cards from Scum
2nd out	Vice President	Receives 1 best card from Vice Scum
2nd last	Vice Scum	Gives 1 best card to Vice President
Last out	Scum	Gives 2 best cards to President

Middle positions (in 5+ player games) have no trading obligation.

RULES

- 1 Lead player plays any valid combination (single, pair, triple, or sequence)
- 2 Each subsequent player must play the same combination type but higher value, or pass
- 3 When all players pass consecutively, the last player who played leads the next trick
- 4 First player to empty their hand finishes 1st, second finishes 2nd, etc.
- 5 Round ends when all but one player has emptied their hand — that player is Scum
- 6 Roles are assigned based on finishing order
- 7 Card trading occurs before the next round begins
- 8 Game continues for a set number of rounds or until a player accumulates enough “President” wins

CARD RANKING

2 > A > K > Q > J > 10 > 9 > 8 > 7 > 6 > 5 > 4 > 3

(Same as Big 2 — 2 is highest)

KEY DIFFERENCES FROM BIG 2

CONCEPT	BIG 2	PRESIDENT
Players	4 (fixed)	4–8 (variable)
Rounds	Single	Multi-round with persistent roles
Card trading	None	Forced exchange based on roles
Who leads	3 of diamonds	Scum (lowest rank)
Win condition	First to empty hand	Accumulate President wins
Deck	Standard 52	Standard 52 (split evenly)
Combinations	Singles, pairs, 5-card hands	Singles, pairs, triples, sequences

WHY THIS TESTS THE ENGINE

President forces the engine to handle:

- ♦ **Multi-round persistence** — roles and scores carry between rounds
- ♦ **Asymmetric card dealing** — trading phase modifies hands before play
- ♦ **Variable player count** — same rules scale from 4 to 8
- ♦ **Role-based turn order** — who leads depends on previous round outcome
- ♦ **State between rounds** — not just within a single game
- ♦ **Component interaction** — deck (deal) + player state (roles) + game flow (rounds)

SPADES

Spades is a partnership trick-taking game for four players (two teams of two). Spades are permanently trump. Before each hand, each player bids how many tricks they expect to win, and the partnership must collectively make their bid to score positively. Bags (overtricks) accumulate toward a penalty.

SETUP

- ♦ 4 players in fixed partnerships (North–South and East–West).
- ♦ Standard 52-card deck. No jokers (jokers are added in some variants; see below).
- ♦ Partners sit opposite each other.
- ♦ The player to the left of the dealer leads.

DEAL

Shuffle and deal all 52 cards clockwise (13 per player). The dealer rotates clockwise each hand.

CARD RANKINGS

Spades (trump): High to low within Spades: A, K, Q, J, 10, 9, 8, 7, 6, 5, 4, 3, 2.

Other suits: A, K, Q, J, 10, 9, 8, 7, 6, 5, 4, 3, 2 within each suit.

Spades always beat non-Spades. Among Spades, higher rank wins.

BIDDING

Starting with the player left of the dealer, each player bids the number of tricks they personally expect to win (0–13). The partnership's bid is the sum of the two partners' bids.

Nil bid: A player may bid Nil (zero), declaring they will win no tricks. If successful, the partnership scores 100 points bonus. If the Nil bidder wins any trick, the bid fails and the partnership scores –100 instead. The partner's bid is scored separately.

Blind Nil (optional): A player with a very weak hand may bid Blind Nil before looking at their cards. Success: +200; failure: –200. Typically restricted to teams that are at least 100 points behind.

PLAY

The player left of the dealer leads first. Players must follow suit if able. If unable to follow suit, they may play any card (including a Spade).

Leading Spades: Spades may not be led until:

- ♦ Spades have been “broken” (a Spade has been played off-suit in a previous trick), OR
- ♦ A player has only Spades remaining in hand.

The highest card of the led suit wins the trick, unless one or more Spades have been played, in which case the highest Spade wins. The winner leads the next trick.

SCORING

At the end of each hand (after all 13 tricks are played):

Made bid: If the partnership won tricks $\geq$ their combined bid:

- ♦ Score = bid $\times$ 10 (for each trick bid and made)
- ♦ Each trick won above the bid (overtrick / “bag”) = +1 point per bag.

Failed bid: If the partnership won tricks $<$ their combined bid:

- ♦ Score = $-(\text{bid} \times 10)$

Bags penalty: Every 10 bags accumulated over the course of the game costs the partnership -100 points. The bag counter resets after each penalty.

Nil bid scoring (separate from partnership’s trick score):

RESULT	NIL SCORE
Nil made	+100
Nil failed	-100
Blind Nil made	+200
Blind Nil failed	-200

END OF GAME

Play continues until one or both partnerships reach 500 points. The partnership with 500+ points wins. If both reach 500 on the same hand, the one with the higher score wins. If tied, play additional hands until the tie breaks.

JOKER VARIANT

Some versions add 2 Jokers: Big Joker (highest Spade) and Little Joker (second-highest Spade). Rank order becomes: Big Joker > Little Joker > A $\spadesuit$ > K $\spadesuit$... 2 $\spadesuit$. One non-Spade card is removed from the deck to maintain 52 total (typically the 2 of Clubs).

ATTRIBUTION

Spades. Traditional American partnership card game, popularized in the 1930s–40s. Public domain. Standard rules confirmed from [Pagat.com](https://www.pagat.com/spades/).